(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Headaches

Most headaches go away on their own and are not a sign of something more serious.

How you can ease headaches yourself

Headaches can last 30 minutes, several hours, or sometimes several days.

Do

- ✓ drink plenty of water
- ✓ get plenty of rest if you also have a cold or the flu
- ✓ try to relax – stress can make headaches worse
- ✓ take paracetamol (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/paracetamol-for-adults/) or ibuprofen (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/ibuprofen-for-adults/)
- ✓ try to stay at home and avoid contact with other people if you also have a high temperature or you do not feel well enough to do your normal activities

Don’t

- ✗ do not skip meals (even if you might not feel like eating anything)
- ✗ do not sleep more than you usually would – it can make the headache worse
- ✗ do not strain your eyes for a long time – for example, by looking at a screen
- ✗ do not drink alcohol

When and where to get medical help

Most headaches are not serious but sometimes you may need medical help.

See a GP if:

- you've tried treating a headache yourself and it's not getting better or is getting worse
- you regularly get headaches

Ask for an urgent GP appointment or get help from NHS 111 if:

- you or a child has a headache and vision or eye problems
- you or a child has a headache triggered or made worse by coughing, sneezing, bending down or exercising
- you or a child has a headache and is being sick (vomiting)
- a child has a headache that's getting worse or wakes them at night
- you have a headache and jaw pain when eating or a sore or tender scalp
- you or a child has any other symptoms you're worried about

You can call 111 or get help from 111 online (Link: https://111.nhs.uk/triage/check-your-symptoms). Call 111 if you need advice for a child under 5 years old.

Call 999 or go to A&E if:

You or a child has a headache and:

- has had a seizure (fit)
- has numbness or weakness in the body or face
- it started suddenly and is extremely painful
- has had a head injury within the last 3 months – for example, from a fall or accident
- are finding it difficult to speak, balance, walk or remember things
- are drowsy or confused
- has loss of vision
- has a rash that does not fade when a glass is rolled over it
- has a very high temperature, a stiff neck, or bright lights are bothering you

Find your nearest A&E (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/service-search/find-an-accident-and-emergency-service/)

Do not drive to A&E. Ask someone to drive you or call 999 and ask for an ambulance.

Bring any medicines you take with you.

What can cause headaches

Common causes of headaches include:

- having a cold (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/common-cold/) or flu (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/flu/)
- stress
- drinking too much alcohol
- bad posture
- eyesight problems
- not eating regular meals
- not drinking enough fluids (dehydration)
- taking too many painkillers

- having your period or during menopause (hormone headache)

Keeping a headache diary might help you work out what triggers your headaches.

Severe headaches can sometimes be caused by a migraine (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/migraine/) or cluster headache (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/cluster-headaches/).

The Migraine Trust has advice about what to record in a headache diary (Link: https://migrainetrust.org/live-with-migraine/self-management/keeping-a-migraine-diary/)

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